

ZERO SUM RPG SCENARIO: 004 - SUBNAUTICA TAPS



REAL-WORLD INSPIRATION

Inspired by geopolitical concerns over the vulnerability of deep-sea transatlantic fiber-optic cables to sabotage by autonomous military submarines.

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BACKGROUND

An unmarked, autonomous submersible drone has clamped onto the MAREA transatlantic cable 2,000 meters below the surface of the Atlantic Ocean. It is slowly injecting corrupted packets into the global banking SWIFT system. The players have been hired by a consortium of banks to take control of an experimental deep-sea ROV (Remotely Operated Vehicle) from a research vessel on the surface, navigate down to the cable, and physically detach the rogue drone.

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THE ZERO SUM TWIST

The players aren't in physical danger from bullets—they are safe in the control room of the surface vessel. However, a mercenary frigate is approaching their coordinates on the surface. They have exactly 40 minutes to complete the delicate underwater ROV operation, pull the drone up for its encrypted hard drive, and flee before the mercenaries board their ship and execute them.

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ZERO SUM CONSISTENCY MATRIX (ZSCM)

- **E (Lethality Expectation) = 6:** The impending arrival of the mercenary frigate guarantees death if the timer runs out.
- **R (Resource Scarcity) = 7:** The ROV is slow, clunky, and its manipulator arms require extreme precision (high Tech/Kinetics DCs).
- **I (Intel Asymmetry) = 8:** The ocean floor is pitch black. The ROV's sonar is limited, and the rogue drone has defensive counter-measures (electric shocks that can fry the ROV).
- **D (Collateral Damage Risk) = 6:** If the players accidentally sever the transatlantic cable with the ROV's cutters, they cause a global internet blackout and their Heat Level becomes permanent.

Total ZSCM Score = 27/30 (High Pressure Time-Attack).

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KEY NPCs & OBSTACLES

- **The Rogue Drone:** It actively fights back against the ROV's manipulator arms.
- **The Approaching Frigate:** A ticking clock. Every failed roll reduces the time until boarding.

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OBJECTIVE

1. Pilot the ROV down 2,000 meters through harsh currents.
2. Carefully detach the rogue drone without severing the internet cable.
3. Win the hacking/manipulation mini-game against the drone's defenses.

4. Flee the surface area before the mercenary frigate arrives.